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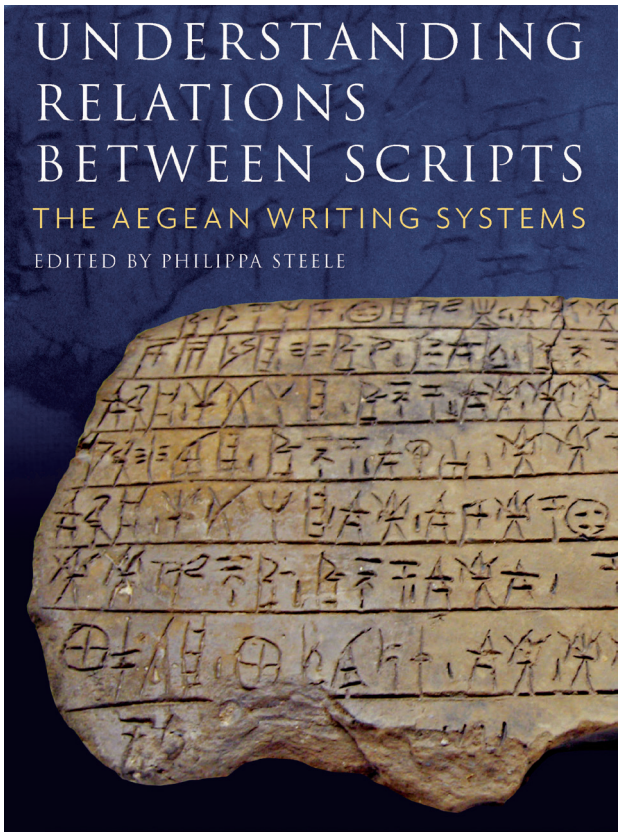

A no man's land: the drive behind *Understanding Relations Between Scripts*

Writing systems do not have a place of their own in the current disciplinary landscape, as they are part of different fields of research. They are a 'no man's land'. As the study of writing systems does not fall into any of the traditional disciplines, their analysis is tackled through different, sometimes contrasting, discipline-specific approaches.

The writing systems of the Bronze and Iron Ages in the Aegean, labelled 'Aegean writing systems', have suffered the same fate, as they have never been dealt with comprehensively. However, in March 2015 the conference *Understanding Relations Between Scripts: The Aegean Writing Systems* (henceforth *URBS*) aimed to move beyond disciplinary boundaries by covering for the first time all Aegean writing systems in a holistic way. The conference explored the complex and intricate relationships between these writing systems. It attracted international participation of well-established scholars and young researchers alike, all exceptionally well placed to lead constructive discussion and carry out a methodical critique of current debates and approaches. This volume, arising from the aforementioned conference, is currently the key source to engage with critical discussions on Aegean writing systems as a whole, therefore filling a considerable gap in current scholarship.

From town to town: wandering around the Aegean

URBS covers two broad geographic areas, namely Crete and Mainland Greece, and Cyprus. The volume is subdivided accordingly, with the first section focusing on writing systems in use on Crete and Mainland Greece (Chapters 2-7), while the second section (Chapters 8-10) is dedicated to Cyprus. The volume's nine contributions present case studies on the Aegean writing systems: Cretan Hieroglyphic, Linear A and Linear B, in use in the Middle and Late Bronze Age predominantly on Crete and Mainland Greece, and the Cypro-Minoan and Cypriot Syllabic scripts, attested on Cyprus in the Late Bronze Age and Iron Age respectively. Of these systems, only Linear B and Cypriot Syllabic have been deciphered and shown to be a written form of Greek, while all others (as well as the languages they encode) still remain enigmatic and, in most cases, poorly understood. Nevertheless, there is enough evidence – mostly palaeographic and epigraphic – to claim that these writing systems bear some relationship to one another.

Drawing on this understanding, the conference explored the interrelations between these systems, how they developed and their context of use. Speakers employed a highly interdisciplinary methodology, encompassing linguistic, palaeographic and epigraphic analysis, typological and iconographic comparison, and archaeological and historical investigation to place the writing practice against its socio-cultural background.

In the opening chapters, the questions of how writing emerged in the Aegean and how best to interpret this process are addressed. The first two papers also offer a theoretical framework within which to place this phenomenon. By assessing current theoretical models of script formation and factors at play when creating a new writing system in the context of secondary script development, Ferrara (Chapter 2) aims to cast a light on the process(es) and reasons behind the adoption and adaptation of writing systems. With the goal of understanding "the effect, impact and significance of new scripts" as well as "the triggers underlying secondary script formation" (p. 31), Ferrara takes four contexts (Crete, Cyprus, Anatolia and Syria) as suitable case studies of specific socio-cultural importance. She groups scripts into pairs (Cretan Hieroglyphic and Anatolian Hieroglyphic, Cypro-Minoan and the Ugaritic alphabet) based on some similarities detectable in their respective trajectories of script formation. Upon investigating the function of early writing and whether it was introduced for administrative or display purposes (i.e. practical vs symbolic), Ferrara suggests overcoming this sharp traditional dichotomy in favour of a more nuanced approach. In fact, as is attested on seals with early Aegean writing, these functions happen to be intertwined.

Cretan seals are the main interest of the volume's second contribution (Chapter 3), where Decorte narrows in on the contextual analysis of Cretan Hieroglyphic. By reckoning the dynamic interplay between writing and art, he tackles the question of how to differentiate between early writing and artistic expression. Taking a theoretical approach, Decorte engages with the problem-

atic definition of what is to be taken as 'sign' of writing and what is not, which leads him to a noteworthy conclusion. He proposes that elements that have been previously deemed as purely decorative in Cretan Hieroglyphic should be understood as representing actual signs, more precisely "potential sematograms" (p. 49), also deserving adequate treatment as an integral part of the script.

In contexts where signs are more clearly singled out and systematised, as is the case of Linear A and Linear B, these can undergo a more targeted typological and palaeographic analysis. Sign types and sign shapes form the focus of Chapters 6-7. Steele and Meissner (Chapter 6) investigate the legitimacy of the backward projection of Linear B sound values to Linear A, which would at least enable us to read Linear A texts. By taking a broad approach encompassing typological, comparative and statistical analysis, they provide convincing arguments for the application of this procedure "in principle and as an approximation" (p. 93), without a close phonetic interpretation being strictly necessary. In fact, although some adaptation undoubtedly took place, this is likely to have worked on a principle of phonetic similarity. A specific set of Linear B signs, the so-called 'extra signs', are discussed by Judson (Chapter 7) as a case study to shed light on the creation of Linear B. Judson does not see these new signs as shortcomings resulting from a failure to adapt Linear A to Greek, but rather as the outcome of an ongoing and creative process with a complex set of motivations behind their introduction and use.

The remaining chapters focus on analysing administrative systems and practices, i.e. the contexts of use of writing systems. Chapters 4 and 5 zoom in on Linear B and explore the origin of the script and the related administrative practice. Tomas (Chapter 4) demonstrates that no single source was responsible for the creation of Linear B, stressing the necessity to separate the origin of the script from that of the administrative system. If Linear B was graphically modelled on Linear A, its administrative system appears to share some links with Cretan Hieroglyphic administration. This circumstance strongly favours the view that Linear B originated on Crete, "where some Cretan Hieroglyphic influence could be felt" (p. 68), and not in Mainland Greece. Crucially, this view aligns with Petrakis's interpretation that a fusion of elements occurred in north-central Crete, which may have been more clearly classifiable in other regions as either Cretan Hieroglyphic or Linear A. In his contribution (Chapter 5), Petrakis sets out to reconstruct the *matrix* of Mycenaean administrations, i.e. the conditions that prompted the emergence of this particular system. By examining the features of earlier Aegean administrations (literate and not) and comparing them to Mycenaean ones, Petrakis draws the conclusion that the latter "responded to novel needs and aspirations, but was also inevitably forged in the 'matrix' of pre-existing structures and practices" (p. 92). The discussion then shifts to Cyprus and its idiosyncratic writing systems, their relationship with the other Aegean systems and their separate development.

The correct identification of Cypro-Minoan signs and their tentative sound values is the main issue discussed in Chapter 8, where Valério demonstrates the potential of "palaeographically-grounded script comparison as a method to investigate Cypro-Minoan sign values" (p. 161). By pinpointing compelling examples of shape-value connections with Linear A and Cypriot Syllabic signs, he stresses the need for a comparative-palaeographical study of the entire Cypro-Minoan corpus. A full-scale palaeographic investigation, moreover, would help elucidate how many scripts Cypro-Minoan represents, as the tripartite traditional classification between Cypro-Minoan 1, 2, 3 has recently raised some criticism. The existence of Cypro-Minoan 3 is still debated, and has been questioned by Duhoux (Chapter 9). However, following a systematic analysis (typological and statistical) of its characteristics, Duhoux ends up reiterating that Cypro-Minoan 3 likely represents an autonomous script; his investigation at least makes an alternative scenario less favourable. In the Iron Age Cypro-Minoan was adapted to transcribe Greek, giving rise to the development of Cypriot Syllabic. Two newly discovered inscriptions, one Cypro-Minoan and one Cypriot Syllabic, are discussed in the final chapter (Chapter 10) by Egetmeyer, who assesses their importance on our understanding of the transition from the former to the latter system, a phase that is still poorly documented.

With its wide-ranging topics and methodologies, this volume makes an outstanding contribution to the current state of research. It is a pioneering undertaking encouraging further future collaborations. These studies have definitely paved the way for turning this 'no man's land' that is the study of writing systems into a promising autonomous discipline in its own right, while being connected to neighbouring fields of research through interdisciplinary bridges.

Ester Salgarella

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